

Case Study: Motorica AG, The Knowledge at Stake

Opening

On Wednesday afternoon, a short message from a regional sales manager reached Jonas Weber with the subject line “Elysion claim risk.” The message said that a landing page description of DriveSphere sounded attractive but created expectations that some dealers would struggle to explain. The same wording had performed well in a digital test. Brand Strategy liked it because it sounded premium. Product Marketing warned that it simplified technical limitations. Digital Growth wanted to keep it because early conversion rates were strong.

Jonas was Head of Marketing Europe at Motorica AG, a German car manufacturer preparing the launch of Elysion, a new electric SUV. A conflict had developed between Brand Strategy and Digital Growth. Brand Strategy wanted to protect a coherent premium narrative. Digital Growth wanted to use data and rapid testing to learn what customers actually cared about. Product Marketing and regional sales teams held additional knowledge about technical features, dealer conversations, and local customer concerns.

Jonas now saw that the conflict was not only about personalities, culture, or power. It was also about knowledge. Different groups knew different things, learned in different ways, and trusted different kinds of evidence. The Elysion launch was at risk because Motorica had knowledge in the organization, but it did not move reliably across the groups that needed it.

Different forms of knowledge

Brand Strategy relied heavily on tacit brand knowledge. Senior campaign managers knew which images felt too cold, which phrases sounded too technical, and which visual cues fit Motorica's premium identity. Much of this knowledge was learned through years of campaign reviews, agency work, and feedback from the brand board. It was difficult to write down completely. A senior brand manager explained: “You can document a color code. You cannot fully document when a message feels like Motorica.”

Digital Growth relied more on explicit and data based knowledge. The team used web analytics, search trends, CRM records, social media responses, and landing page tests. Its members could show tables, conversion rates, and customer segments. Yet digital knowledge was also incomplete. Early test results depended on sample composition, wording, timing, and channel context. Tobias Neumann admitted that “a winning test variant can still be a weak brand idea if we misunderstand why people clicked.”

Product Marketing held technical and translational knowledge. It knew which DriveSphere features were stable, which functions depended on market-specific regulation, and which claims dealers could explain credibly. Regional sales teams held local customer knowledge. They heard questions from fleet customers, leasing partners, dealers, and early electric vehicle adopters. This knowledge often appeared in emails, calls, or informal notes, not in a single system accessible to all teams.

Knowledge management problems

Jonas asked Sophie Lang, Head of Marketing Learning, to map the knowledge flow. She identified three problems. First, Motorica did not always know what it knew. Customer concerns about software updates, charging planning, and warranty wording existed in regional emails and dealer notes, but they were not systematically connected to campaign decisions. Second, people could not always articulate what they knew. Brand Strategy could often reject a phrase as “not Motorica,” but struggled to explain the judgment in a way Digital Growth could use. Third, people did not always share what they knew. Digital Growth uploaded test results to the analytics workspace, but Brand Strategy rarely visited it. Brand Strategy stored agency rationales in presentation decks, but Digital Growth saw them as polished arguments rather than reusable knowledge.

The problem became concrete in the DriveSphere landing page debate. Digital Growth tested three descriptions. One emphasized “AI based driving intelligence,” one emphasized “personalized route and charging support,” and one emphasized “a quieter, more confident electric journey.” The third version generated the highest click-through rate. Brand Strategy preferred it because it fit the premium narrative. Product Marketing warned that it could hide the technical conditions under which DriveSphere worked. Regional sales added that customers in some markets asked practical questions about data privacy and software updates before they responded to emotional claims.

Socialization reinforced the divide. New employees in Brand Strategy learned by attending campaign reviews, observing senior comments, and absorbing judgment through repeated exposure. New employees in Digital Growth learned through analytics dashboards, test documentation, and weekly performance reviews. Product Marketing learned through product clinics with engineers and dealer briefings. Each group developed

competent members, but the competence remained partly local. The marketing department had learning routines, but few routines created shared understanding across groups.

Decision point

Jonas concluded that another coordination meeting would not be enough. The department needed a knowledge management concept for launch work. The concept had to respect tacit brand expertise, use explicit data responsibly, incorporate technical and regional knowledge, and create learning across groups before campaign decisions became fixed. Jonas wanted a practical concept that could be introduced before the next Elysion launch cycle without creating a bureaucratic reporting system.

Your group task

You are advising Jonas Weber, Head of Marketing Europe at Motorica AG. Your group works on this case only. Prepare a 3 to 5 minute presentation with 2 to 3 slides. Use evidence from the case and end with a concrete recommendation that Jonas could implement before the next launch meeting.

1. What knowledge is at stake in the case? Distinguish implicit versus explicit and technical versus market knowledge.
2. Where do you see problems of knowing what the organization knows, articulating what people know, and sharing knowledge?
3. Develop a knowledge management concept for the Elysion launch.

Disclaimer

This teaching case is fictional and intended solely for classroom use. Generative AI has been used to develop and refine this case.